

1920–1929

THE NEW KNITWEAR

In the late 1910s women began to wear cardigans and long sweater tunics, mainly for sports or resort wear. Coco Chanel famously donned a long jersey sweater on the Normandy beach as early as 1913. This knitted textile had previously been used only for underwear but Chanel fashioned it into coats and suits. Knitwear was the perfect fit for the active, modern woman, personified by the French tennis ace Suzanne Lenglen who patronized Chanel's rival Jean Patou. While not everyone could afford his patterned sweaters – with matching accessories – cheaper versions were available for the mass market. Knitted cardigans, tunics, coatees, or entire knitwear ensembles were easy to put on, comfortable to wear, and survived transport in a suitcase to the Riviera or the Alps.

JEAN PATOU

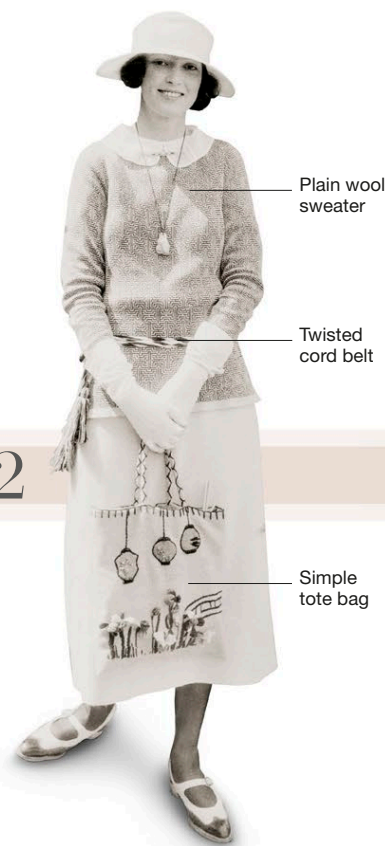
In the Paris of the 1920s and early 30s the dashing Jean Patou was as famous and successful as Coco Chanel. Often credited with the invention of the knitted sweater and swimsuit, and sportswear in general, the couturier dressed sports stars, actresses, and dancers such as the Dolly sisters and Josephine Baker. The French tennis champion Suzanne Lenglen, a major popularizer of *la mode sportive*, here models a long, belted tunic sweater with zigzag bands on sleeves and hem, a pencil-pleated, white crêpe de Chine skirt, and a fashionable felt cloche hat. Patou also designed the daring short-sleeved cotton attire Lenglen wore on court.

Suzanne Lenglen



1927

Stylish sportswear This young woman steps off the court in style, wearing a tennis dress of white crêpe de Chine with a knee-length pencil-pleated skirt. Her simple silhouette is fashionably slimline.



1922

On vacation For her spring holiday this stylish woman has accessorized a hip-length tunic sweater with a twisted belt. The white of her plain skirt is picked up in her hat, Peter Pan collar, long gloves, and two-tone bar shoes.



Plain, black wool jersey

Black, satin cuffs

Finely pleated jersey skirt

Jersey Coco Chanel's perfect "little black dress" is in fact made in two parts from one of her trademark materials: wool jersey. The unlined skirt, attached to a deep waistband, is paired with a short sweater edged with satin.